

Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR

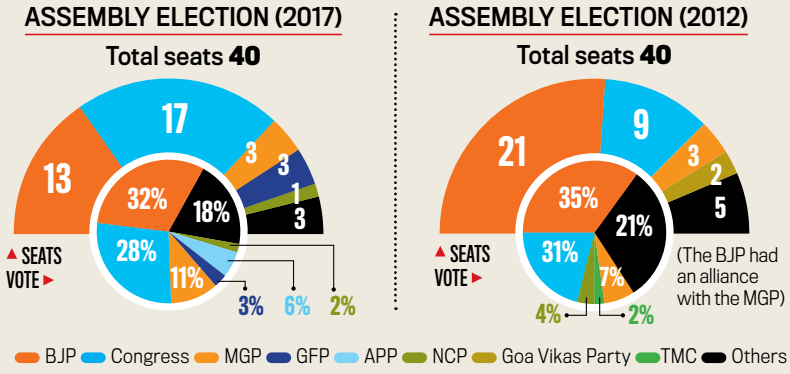
THREE'S A CROWD (from left) AAP's CM candidate Amit Palekar in Panjim; Goa CM Pramod Sawant in Sankhali; and independent Utpal Parrikar (right) in Panjim

feels he has scored on both infrastructure and social welfare, and that it will suffice to help the BJP win over 22 seats in a total of 40 when Goa votes on February 14. "The wide network of roads and bridges, the online delivery of services...Goa has never seen these before," Sawant tells INDIA TODAY. Despite his optimism, perhaps not even the most ambitious punter in Goa's controversial casinos could bet too confidently on any one party taking over half of the state's constituencies. Goa's political map used to be a virtually bipolar one—the smaller parties cohered around the Congress or the BJP. No longer. With parties like AAP and TMC in the fray as serious players, the contest this time is way more fragmented, complex and, therefore, unpredictable.

It was a dizzying game of predatory politics that took the BJP from 13 MLAs to its highest-ever tally of 27. Sawant put the absolute majority to good, productive use—at least politically. "We won all the zilla parishad and municipal elections with a huge majority because the people showed faith in us," he says. That, however, did not insulate him from anger over three burning issues—all tied to that difficult balance between the environment, livelihoods and macro-economics. One, iron ore mining, which still stands effectively banned by the Supreme Court; two, the proposal to double Goa's coal-carrying facilities, altering natural structures from the coast all the way to the Ghats; and three, green concerns over a proposed IIT campus at Melauli. The state's desperate green warriors see the standstill on iron ore as a reprieve but it was bound to affect the economy—mining was Goa's largest industry. The ban is estimated to have resulted in annual economic losses of Rs 6,000 crore since 2018, directly or indirectly affecting the livelihood of 250,000 people. So Sawant has voted for holding firm on

CRUMBLING PIE

The BJP and Congress have, till now, dominated Goa's politics

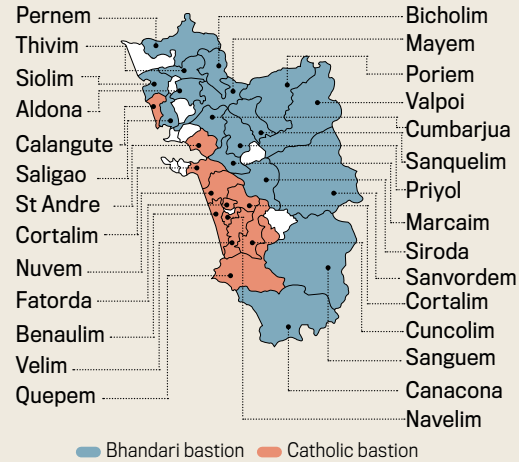


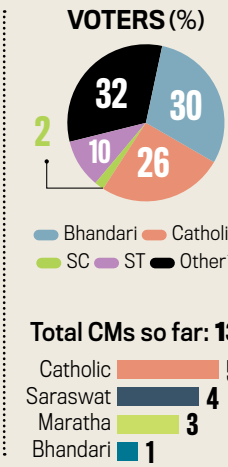
LOK SABHA (2014) Total seats 2 — BJP 2

LOK SABHA (2019) Total seats 2 — INC 1, BJP 1

COMMUNITY MAP

When it comes to political representation, the Bhandaris have fared the worst





'Other': 10 per cent Muslim (mainly concentrated in Bicholim, Vasco and Madgaon); 7 per cent Marathas (mainly in Sankhali, Mandrem); 2 per cent Saraswat Brahmins (mainly in Panaji, Madgaon); 13 per cent are other non-SC/ ST. Pernem is a reserved seat for SCs, who have sizable numbers in Vasco too. STs are in good numbers in Canacona and Fatorda.

Graphic by ASIT ROY